

“Mankind must put an end to war or war will put an end to mankind”

US PRESIDENT JOHN F KENNEDY, 25 SEPTEMBER 1961

centres deep within the territory of any potential enemy. Further refinements included the use of multiple warheads on a single missile, and submarines that were able to fire nuclear weapons while hidden underwater.

The US, exploiting its technical superiority over the Soviet Union, made repeated attempts to construct missile-launched anti-ballistic-missile systems, of which the space-based “Star Wars” defence was the most ambitious. None, however, were successful. Meanwhile, some soldiers were equipped with NBC (Nuclear, Biological, Chemical) suits to help those who survived an initial blast to

operate in a radiation-contaminated atmosphere. In an attempt to ensure the continuity of government in the event of nuclear onslaught, extensive underground bunkers were constructed to shelter officials at the onset of war.

NUCLEAR DEADLOCK

In terms of civilian casualties, however, it was clear that hundreds of millions of people on both sides would be killed if a full nuclear exchange took place, and that life for those who did survive might well be unendurable. Thus, US military policy during the 1960s was driven by the doctrine of Mutually Assured Destruction (MAD), the acronym reflecting the conviction that a nuclear war was effectively unwinnable.

This was the Cold War, when the antagonism between West and East was, paradoxically, moderated by the power of nuclear weapons, each side fearing the consequences of an all-out “hot war” (although during the Cuban missile crisis of 1962, East-West tensions almost let to nuclear war, after US spy aircraft discovered Soviet missile bases in Cuba). This fear did not, however, prevent the leaders of the US and the Soviet Union from aggressively pursuing their interests elsewhere. In what became termed “limited warfare”, the armies of the Communist East and capitalist West engaged in military operations to establish dominance over each other. They refrained from direct confrontation, and instead supported other states or groups in secondary conflicts.

In many cases, local disputes became proxy wars between the superpowers. In Vietnam (see pp.398–99), the people’s attempt to overthrow colonial rule was transformed into full-scale war by the provision of Soviet (and Chinese) military aid to the Vietnamese Communists, countered by US aid to France, and finally full US military involvement. In the Middle East, the US aligned itself with Israel, while the Soviet Union supported its Arab opponents. In conflicts in Africa, and Central and South America, military assistance given to one side was countered by similar support from the rival superpower. The Cold War may not have resulted in nuclear war, but the tactic of avoiding direct conflict between the superpowers had the side-effect of exporting warfare all around the globe.



▲ AN UNDERWATER LAUNCH

A Trident ballistic missile is fired from a submarine far out in the ocean. The Trident missile has a range of 7,100km (4,400 miles) and can carry eight independently targeted nuclear warheads.

▼ AN NBC SUIT

The Nuclear, Biological, Chemical (NBC) suit provided basic protection against radiological and other hazards. It could be worn for several days before needing to be replaced.

